bring it down at all costs. He advised them to set up more vaccination centres so that vaccination rate can be increased as supplies increase and asked them to stay vigilant about the expiry dates of the vaccines.

In the entire period, from September to April, the Centre dispatched many advisories and teams to states with high caseloads to assist them in strategizing appropriate and timely responses to the surge of cases. From the time of the peaking of the first wave in September 2020 continuing through the second wave, the Centre sent a total of 75 high-level, multidisciplinary teams comprising public health experts and clinicians from reputable institutions to 22 states/UTs. Fifty-three of these central teams were stationed in 30 districts of Maharashtra, 11 districts of Chhattisgarh, nine districts of Punjab and three districts of Gujarat all the way until April 2021. In addition to constantly appraising the states of their findings and recommendations, the Centre also identified high-impact districts and reviewed COVID-19 response in them from time to time. In addition to these, over 25 advisories were sent to states between September 2020 and April 2021, reminding them not to be complacent and to keep strict vigil regarding COVID-19-appropriate behaviour.

On 23 March, the Ministry of Home Affairs issued an advisory with updated SOPs for effective control of COVID-19 titled ‘States/UTs mandated to strictly enforce Test-Track-Treat protocol, Containment measures, COVID-19 appropriate behaviour and SOPs on various activities.’[18]